Lesson 31: Listening and Speaking: Schools and Creativity

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 4: Education and Creativity

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 4.1: Listening and Speaking - Schools and Creativity; 4.2: Vocabulary Review.

In this lesson

You will watch two minutes of a famous TED Talk, "Do Schools Kill Creativity?" by Sir Ken Robinson. He tells a true story about his friend Gillian Lynne, a girl who could not sit still at school. You will learn words about school, learning problems and dance, and talk with your tutor about creativity.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Understand the main idea, the details and the order of the story about Gillian Lynne.
- Use new words such as concentrate, fidget, learning disorder, specialist and calm down.
- Say the genre, audience and purpose of a talk.
- Give your opinion about creativity and school subjects.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
concentrate	to give all your attention to what you are doing	She couldn't concentrate or sit still.
fidget	to make a lot of small, restless movements because you are nervous or bored	She fidgeted.
learning disorder	problems or difficulty with learning	The school thought Gillian had a learning disorder.
ADHD	the book calls it a learning disorder: children with it move around a lot and have problems concentrating	What is ADHD?
a specialist	a doctor who knows a lot about one kind of problem	Her mother took Gillian to see a special doctor, a specialist.
medication	medicine from a doctor	Did the doctor give Gillian medication?
calm down	to stop being angry, upset, excited or nervous	When children have too much energy, parents tell them to calm down.
soloist	someone who dances alone on the stage	Soloists are usually the most talented dancers.

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
musical theater	a kind of performance where people sing and dance on stage	She helped create some very successful musical theater productions.
founded	started (a company or a school)	She founded a dance company.

Rules and explanations

Genre, audience and purpose

- **Genre** = the type of video (the book's choices: TED Talk, video from YouTube, news program, talk show).
- **Audience** = the people who will watch it. Ask: "Who will watch this video?"
- **Purpose** = why the speaker tells the story. A story can have more than one purpose.

Word families and useful phrases

- invent (verb) - invented (past) - inventor (person) - inventions (things).
- **founded** is the past of *found* (= start a company). Do not confuse it with *found*, the past of *find*.
- **sit still** = sit without moving: Gillian couldn't sit still.
- **turn in homework** = give your homework to the teacher: She turned in her homework late.

Practice

1. Vocabulary. Match each picture or definition to a word: *fidgeting, concentrate, learning disorder, invent, a specialist, radio, ballet, tap dance, soloist, musical theater production, multimillionaire, calm down, medication.* (The pictures are in the printed lesson.)

1. focus; think about something; to give all your attention to what you're doing
2. to create or produce something for the first time
3. Picture: little girls practicing a dance routine
4. Picture: people singing and dancing on stage in the musical *Cats*
5. to make a lot of small, restless movements because you are nervous or bored
6. Picture: dance shoes
7. Picture: pills coming out of a bottle
8. a person who has a lot of money
9. Picture: a doctor in a white coat with a clipboard
10. problems or difficulty with learning
11. someone who dances alone on the stage
12. to stop being angry, upset, excited, or nervous
13. Picture: an old-fashioned radio

2. Watch for the main idea. Watch the talk from 15:23 to 17:32 (links in "Watch online"). Then answer aloud and record yourself:

- Who is Gillian and what problem did she have as a child?
- Gillian's mother took her to see a doctor. What did the doctor do? What was his advice?
- Was Gillian successful in life? How do you know?

3. Put it in order. Number the four summary paragraphs in your printed lesson ("Put it in order") from 1 to 4.

- A. "After that, Gillian went to a dance school ..."
- B. "Her mother took Gillian to see a special doctor ..."
- C. "Sir Ken Robinson has a friend called Gillian ..." (this is number 1)
- D. "Before he left the room, the doctor turned on the radio ..."

4. Listen for detail. Watch again. Choose the correct answer.

1. Who is Gillian? (Choose all correct answers.) a famous dancer / Sir Ken Robinson's friend / a doctor
2. How old was Gillian when this story took place? 10 / 8 / 6
3. When was Gillian in school? the 1930s / 2006 / the 1960s
4. Why did Gillian's school think she had a learning disorder? She fidgeted. / She couldn't concentrate. / She turned in her homework late. / All of the above.
5. Where did Gillian's mother take her? to see her father / to see a special doctor / to see Sir Ken Robinson
6. What did the doctor do before he left the room? he gave Gillian medication / he gave Gillian food / he turned on the radio / he turned on the lights
7. Why did the doctor turn on the music? (Choose all correct answers.) He wanted to show Gillian's mom that Gillian had a special talent. / He thought Gillian was a dancer. / He thought Gillian might like music.
8. The doctor told Gillian's mother to ... give her medication / take her to a dance school / give her more homework
9. True or false: Gillian became a famous dancer.
10. True or false: Gillian was not successful in her career.
11. True or false: Gillian earned a lot of money as a dancer and choreographer.
12. True or false: The doctor told Gillian to "calm down."

5. Genre, audience and purpose. Choose, and say why.

1. What is the genre of this video? TED Talk / video from YouTube / news program / talk show
2. Who is the most likely audience? young children in school / young people who like to travel / teachers / people who think education isn't important
3. What is the purpose of this story? (Choose all correct answers.) to help listeners understand the importance of creativity / to help listeners understand that different people learn in different ways

/ to persuade listeners to go to dance school

6. Vocabulary review. First study the unit's Quizlet flashcards (link in "Watch online"). Then complete the sentences. Spell the words correctly.

A. *fidget, concentrate, learning disorder, invented, radio, ballet, tap, soloist, musical theater*

1. Young children often _____ in school. They move around a lot and they find it difficult to sit still.
2. Children who have a _____ often have problems with learning.
3. Please stop making so much noise. I'm trying to do my homework and I can't _____.
4. _____ is a kind of performance where people sing and dance on stage.
5. The _____ in the ballet did a beautiful dance.
6. Thomas Edison _____ the lightbulb.
7. I like all kinds of dance including _____ and _____.
8. I listen to the _____ a lot while I'm driving.

B. *multimillionaire, calm down, medication, ADHD, inventor, inventions, founded, a specialist*

1. Gillian's mother took her to see _____.
2. Gillian Lynne earned a lot of money doing her work and she became a _____.
3. Gillian Lynne _____ the Gillian Lynne Dance Company. That means she started the company.
4. Sometimes my children have too much energy and I have to tell them to _____.
5. _____ is a learning disorder. Children with this disorder have to move around a lot, and they have problems concentrating and learning.
6. The doctor gives me _____ when I'm sick.
7. Alexander Graham Bell was a famous _____. He invented the telephone.
8. People have made many new _____ in the last 100 years such as antibiotics, the TV, the smart phone, and the electric car.

Speak with your tutor

- "Before I watch, ask me one at a time: What is creativity? What is a learning disorder? What is ADHD? Correct my mistakes."
- "I will retell the story about Gillian Lynne in the past tense. Tell me what I missed and correct my verbs."
- "Let's discuss: Is learning science, English, and math more important than learning art, music, and dance? Ask me why."
- "Ask me: What did you think of this story? What does Sir Ken Robinson want us to learn from it? Does moving help you think?"
- "Give me a definition of a word from this lesson, and I will say the word."

Read aloud

- cre·a·TIV·i·ty
- CON·cen·trate
- FID·get·ing
- learning dis·OR·der
- SPE·cial·ist
- med·i·CA·tion
- bal·LET (American English)
- SO·lo·ist
- mul·ti·mil·lion·AIRE
- cho·re·OG·ra·pher

Watch online

- TED Talk "Do Schools Kill Creativity?" by Sir Ken Robinson (watch 15:23 to 17:32): https://www.ted.com/talks/sir_ken_robinson_do_schools_kill_creativity
- The same talk on YouTube, starting at 15:23: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iG9CE55wbtY&t=923s
- Quizlet flashcards for this unit's words: https://quizlet.com/513616908/do-schools-kill-creativity-gillian-lynne-anecdote-flash-cards/

Answer key

1. 1 concentrate, 2 invent, 3 tap dance, 4 musical theater production, 5 fidgeting, 6 ballet, 7 medication, 8 multimillionaire, 9 a specialist, 10 learning disorder, 11 soloist, 12 calm down, 13 radio.

2. (book: from the summary paragraphs in exercise 3) Gillian is Sir Ken Robinson's friend. As a child she couldn't concentrate or sit still. The doctor turned on the radio, left the room with her mother and watched her dance. He said: "She's a dancer. Take her to dance school." Yes, she was successful: she became a very successful dancer and became very wealthy.

3. 1 C, 2 B, 3 D, 4 A (book: the full summary in Lesson 32 has this order).

4. (book) 1 a famous dancer; Sir Ken Robinson's friend. 2 8. 3 the 1930s. 4 All of the above. 5 to see a special doctor. 6 he turned on the radio. 7 All three answers are correct. 8 take her to a dance school. 9 True. 10 False. 11 True. 12 False.

5. 1 TED Talk. 2 teachers (the talk is about schools and how children learn). 3 the first two: the importance of creativity, and that different people learn in different ways.

6. (book) A: 1 fidget, 2 learning disorder, 3 concentrate, 4 Musical theater, 5 soloist, 6 invented, 7 ballet, tap, 8 radio. B: 1 a specialist, 2 multimillionaire, 3 founded, 4 calm down, 5 ADHD, 6 medication, 7 inventor, 8 inventions.

My notes